whether it was sunny or raining or even snowing (like how it was when we reached Jammu and Kashmir), I walked barefoot. As the Yatra progressed, I realized that millions of Indians were also walking around us without any footwear. It's so strange that our privilege made us blind to their plight. I'm sure we all notice these things, but until it pricks us, it doesn't compel us to do anything about it. And that got me thinking of all those vulnerable and downtrodden people we see every day but ignore because our social media accounts are abuzz with how India will soon be a 5-trillion-dollar economy or how Amrit Kaal has arrived. It's so easy to become distracted by the irrelevant that we lose sense of our own humanity. The Yatra gave me the opportunity to confront my own blindness and experience first-hand the plight of the poor, the downtrodden, the Adivasi, the Dalits, the members of the minority communities, women and every other section of society that needs care and protection.

The Yatra also gave me a wonderful opportunity to interact with Rahul Gandhi and get to know him better. The topics we discussed ranged from spirituality, diet, history, international politics and health. I was amazed by the scale and depth of his knowledge on each of these matters. But I also saw a deeply sensitive side to him. There was a time during the Yatra when my father's health deteriorated. When Rahul Gandhi heard about it, he took the initiative to arrange for his treatment in Germany. He also allowed me ten days' leave from the Yatra to ensure that I was able to travel with my father. Since then and until the time my father passed away, he (along with the party's general secretary K.C. Venugopal) constantly enquired after my father and went out of his way to ensure we had all the help we needed. As a son, I can never forget what he did for my father, and I will always remain indebted and grateful to him. I have read that former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee acknowledged former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's role in saving his life by arranging for his kidney treatment in the United States by making him a member of the Indian delegation to the United Nations in 1988. I felt something similar towards Rahul Gandhi. The manner in which he took special care of my family and me while he was in the middle of the gruelling Yatra made me realize that he was no different from his father.